

Low Plurality Winner (LPW) Data Sources

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Background

The `recent_lpw` variable flags whether a locale's state had a statewide race (governor or U.S. senator) won with less than 40% of the vote within 10 years of the RCV ballot measure. The two cases in this study:

- **Maine:** Governor Paul LePage won in 2010 with 37.6% ([Ballotpedia](#))
- **Alaska:** Senator Lisa Murkowski won in 2010 with 39.7% (write-in) ([Ballotpedia](#))

The current project uses a hand-built CSV (`data/raw/statewide_elections_lpw_2006_2018.csv`) covering the 6 states in the dataset. This is sufficient for the current scope.

U.S. Senate returns (MEDSL)

For reference, a consolidated U.S. Senate general election returns file (1976–2020) from the MIT Election Data + Science Lab has been downloaded.

- **Citation:** MIT Election Data and Science Lab, 2017, “U.S. Senate 1976–2020”, <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/PEJ5QU>, Harvard Dataverse
- **File:** `data/raw/medsl_senate_1976_2020.csv`
- **Download:** Harvard Dataverse API, file ID 7609736

```
download.file(  
  url = "https://dataverse.harvard.edu/api/access/datafile/7609736?format=original",  
  destfile = "data/raw/medsl_senate_1976_2020.csv",  
  mode = "wb"  
)
```

Senate races won with < 40% (2006+)

```
library(dplyr)  
  
sen <- read.csv("../data/raw/medsl_senate_1976_2020.csv")  
  
senate_winners <- sen %>%  
  filter(stage == "gen", writein == "False") %>%  
  group_by(year, state, state_po, totalvotes) %>%  
  summarise(winner_votes = max(candidatevotes), .groups = "drop") %>%  
  mutate(winner_share = round(100 * winner_votes / totalvotes, 1))
```

```
senate_winners %>%
  filter(winner_share < 40, year >= 2006) %>%
  arrange(winner_share) %>%
  select(year, state, winner_share) %>%
  knitr::kable(caption = "U.S. Senate races won with < 40% (2006+)")
```

Table 1: U.S. Senate races won with < 40% (2006+)

year	state	winner_share
2016	LOUISIANA	26.8
2020	GEORGIA	32.9
2010	ALASKA	35.6

Alaska 2010 appears at 35.6% — this is Joe Miller’s plurality among non-write-in candidates. Murkowski’s write-in share was 39.7%. Either way, no candidate cleared 40%, confirming the LPW classification.

Future research

MEDSL does not publish a consolidated governor returns file. If expanding to new locales, governor races would need to be checked manually (e.g. from Ballotpedia) or scraped. Low-plurality governors are rare; for the current 8-locale dataset the hand-built CSV is sufficient.